

Glorification and Exclusion in the Housewives of *Modern Family*

Revenge of the Housewife: Women & Domesticity in US Film & Television

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Modern Family (2009), is a popular American sitcom that follows the lives of the Pritchett-Dunphy-Tucker family, a large and diverse family that includes three interconnected households. The first household follows Jay Pritchett, his young second wife Gloria Delgado-Pritchett, and her son Manny. Jay's daughter Claire Dunphy and her husband Phil along with their three children are the second household the show focuses on. The third household followed on the show is Jay's son, Mitchell Pritchett, his husband Cameron Tucker, and their adopted daughter Lily. The series is filmed in a mockumentary style, using sit down interview styled confessions that reveal the characters' inner thoughts and handheld cameras. Central to the show's plot are the mothers on the show- Claire Dunphy and Gloria Delgado-Pritchett. Claire represents the archetype of the overachieving housewife, who is organized and dedicated which is often taken for granted. Gloria, on the other hand, embodies the exotic trophy wife, celebrated for her beauty and charisma but frequently limited by Colombian stereotypes. *Modern Family* explores the themes of glorification and exclusion, revealing how these women are both celebrated for their contributions to family life while simultaneously confined by their housewife status. In this essay, I will explore how the characters of Gloria and Claire reveal how the glorification of housewives often leads to their exclusion from broader power structures. I will

do so by analyzing their portrayal in the Season 3 episode, "Hit and Run" using academic works to support my claim.

In the beginning of the episode, Claire and Phil run into Duane Bailey, a member of the town's current town council. Claire dislikes him because he refused to put up a stop sign at an intersection that she believes is hazardous. He speaks to her in a condescending tone. When Phil mentions that she should run for office, Claire instantly gets excited by the idea of how she would help the community. However, following this joy her thoughts jump to her domestic duties. Phil reassures her that he will help her and that she isn't alone in their housework. In the first chapter of "The Feminine Mystique," Friedan discusses the concept of "the problem that has no name," where women are often trapped in domestic roles that prevent them from achieving personal fulfillment and professional success.

All admit to being deeply frustrated at times by the lack of privacy, the physical burden, the routine of family life, the confinement of it. However, none would give up her home and family if she had the choice to make again. Few women would want to thumb their noses at husbands, children and community and go off on their own. Those who do may be talented individuals, but they rarely are successful women. (Friedan 20)

Claire's experience reflects this as her potential political career is being derailed by her domestic responsibilities before it has even begun. When Claire goes down to the city council to begin her run, she sees Bailey who again speaks down to her. He makes it clear that her role as a housewife doesn't belong in politics: "I've won six straight elections. I don't plan on losing to some bored

housewife. So don't quit your lack of a day job." As she attempts to retort, she ironically gets a call from her daughter's school which whisks her back to her domestic duties. The condescending attitude of Bailey exemplifies the obstacles that Friedan argues women face when they attempt to move beyond traditional roles. After Claire's interaction with Duane, we cut to a scene of Phil at home with their two other children, Alex and Luke. Phil accidentally punches Luke in the eye as he attempts to open a band aid and gives Alex a drowsy allergy medication that knocks her out. It shows how Claire's role as a housewife is important and how inadequate Phil is at controlling the household. When Claire learns of how Phil mishandled all the children that day, she decides she won't be running for town council. Claire tells Phil: "I take my eye off the ball for one minute, and I've got one in a coma, one with a black eye, and one running a crime ring." The inadequacy of Claire's husband, Phil, to fully support her in their shared domestic duties underscores the gendered division of labor within the household. Despite Phil's reassurance that he will help with domestic responsibilities, Claire's concerns about childcare and household management persist, reflecting the societal expectation that women prioritize family duties over professional endeavors. As Claire navigates the challenges of balancing her domestic responsibilities with her political ambitions, her decision not to pursue the council position reinforces the theme of exclusion, where traditional gender roles confine women to domestic spheres, limiting their opportunities for professional growth and fulfillment.

Then there is the discontented suburban wife who raises hell at the PTA; morbidly depressed destroys her children and dominates her husband whom she envies for going out into the business world. "The wife, having worked before marriage, or at least having

been educated for some kind of intellectual work, finds herself in the lamentable position of being 'just a housewife.' (Friedan 51-52)

Gloria Pritchett's experiences in the episode "Hit and Run," underscore the intersectional challenges women of color face, reflecting Bell Hooks' writings from "Black Women: Shaping Feminist History." Hooks explores and criticizes Friedan's work through the experience of a black woman and explores how people of color are often left out of conversations regarding their own oppression.

[Friedan] did not speak of the needs of women without children, without homes. She ignored the existence of all non-white women and poor white women. She did not tell readers whether it was more fulfilling to be a maid, a babysitter, a factory worker, a clerk, or a prostitute, than to be a leisure class housewife. (Hooks 1-2)

Jay is Gloria's second husband and before her marriage to him she was a lower-class, single mother working odd jobs. The glorification of Gloria as a trophy wife excludes her from conversations where she can use her expertise. This is evident in Gloria's interactions and the dismissive attitudes she encounters, which reflect the broader societal tendency to undermine women of color. Gloria, a Colombian immigrant, faces condescension and stereotyping throughout the series, which are compounded by her gender and ethnicity. In the episode, Gloria attempts to help Manny with his homework and her husband, Jay, with his trouble at his business. However, they don't take her advice seriously. In an interview scene where characters can reveal their inner thoughts, Gloria yells: "It's very frustrating. I have all the answers!" as she

looks into the camera. Throughout the episode they continue to ignore her advice. In one scene, Gloria begins to give advice to Haley after learning that someone stole her money only to be cut off by Jay giving his own advice. This illustrates Hooks' argument that women of color are often marginalized, and their voices devalued.

Our presence in movement activities did not count, as white women were convinced that "real" blackness meant speaking the patois of poor black people, being uneducated, streetwise, and a variety of other stereotypes. If we dared to criticize the movement or to assume responsibility for reshaping feminist ideas and introducing new ideas, our voices were tuned out, dismissed, silenced. (Hooks 11-12)

This interaction highlights the systemic barriers that prevent women like Gloria from being taken seriously, thus confining them to domestic roles. Gloria's struggle for recognition extends to her efforts to communicate her concerns effectively. Although she is a central figure in her household, her insights are frequently overlooked, reducing her to a stereotype of the passionate, exotic woman. This reduction not only devalues her contributions but also limits her potential for broader societal engagement. Hooks' theory emphasizes that such marginalization results from intersecting oppressions of race, class, and gender, which are portrayed in Gloria's character.

Towards the end of the episode, there is a scene where the interactions between Claire and Gloria reveal deeper insights into the complexities of gender roles and the intersectional challenges women face as housewives. In their work "Feminism Ain't Funny," Simmons and Rich discuss how female characters in sitcoms are often constrained by stereotypical roles that

mainstream television produces. (Simmons, Rich 1) Gloria approaches Claire with a drink and offers her advice after hearing Claire's decision to not run for town council. Initially, Claire, much like Jay and Manny, is uninterested in Gloria's advice. This reflects a common theme where women's insights are often dismissed- glorified for their household duties but excluded from voicing their opinions. However, eventually Claire confides in Gloria that her reluctance to run for council stems not from her domestic responsibilities but from a fear of failure: "I haven't done anything outside of my house in 18 years. I don't want the first thing I do to be a complete failure." This admission underscores the profound impact of societal expectations on Claire's sense of identity. Gloria, in response, tells Claire a story about her cousin who, despite being unattractive and finishing last in a beauty pageant, faced her fears and survived. By focusing on beauty, Gloria speaks from her own experience of how society values women, but she uses this to encourage Claire by emphasizing resilience rather than external validation. Gloria's story and encouragement are rooted in her understanding of societal pressures and the importance of overcoming personal fears. Simmons and Rich argue that sitcoms frequently cast women in roles that emphasize their domestic responsibilities and undercut their aspirations, portraying them as "fun-killers" who thwart the more adventurous or carefree desires of their male counterparts.

Second and third wave feminism and an equal rights movement seem to have only relieved television women of their sense of humor and capacity for fun—a curious thematic development in situational comedies. In this sitcom evolution, woman becomes mother, mother becomes nag. (Simmons, Rich 2)

Claire's fear of stepping outside her domestic role and Gloria's struggle to be taken seriously reflect these constraints. Claire listens to Gloria and decides to run for council after all. This moment is pivotal as it demonstrates how Gloria's support helps Claire overcome her fear and societal pressure, embodying a break from the "fun-killer" stereotype. Furthermore, when Claire tells Jay that he should listen to Gloria's advice, he does, and she helps him secure a big deal because of her physical appearance. This interaction highlights another layer of complexity in gender dynamics. Simmons and Rich discuss how these interactions can turn hierarchical relationships on their head without dismantling oppressive narratives:

For this reason, capital can turn the hierarchical relationship between men and women on its head without dismantling oppressive narratives that model the conditions of capitalist consumption. In reversing the roles of intellectual and idiot, women continue to bear the guilt and now also the responsibility of derailing male pleasure. [...] When women attempt to escape their role as bearers of guilt and acquire pleasure, they must do so either by becoming 'men' or turning themselves back into sex objects. (Simmons, Rich 11).

Gloria's ability to leverage her appearance to help Jay underscores this, showing that while she can momentarily disrupt traditional gender roles, the underlying oppressive structures remain intact. Additionally, Claire decides to run for town council at the end of the episode, signifying a momentary break from her domestic confines and an attempt to assert her identity beyond being a housewife. However, this decision also highlights the ongoing struggle women face in balancing societal expectations with personal aspirations.

In conclusion, the characters of Gloria and Claire in the season 3 episode, “Hit and Run” reveal how the glorification of housewives often leads to their exclusion. Through Claire, the episode demonstrates the restrictive nature of being a housewife, which confines women to domestic responsibilities and undermines their professional aspirations. Similarly, Gloria’s experiences reflect the intersectional challenges faced by women of color. Despite her beauty and charisma, Gloria is often marginalized, and her insights dismissed. The ending, where Claire decides to pursue her political ambitions and Jay lets Gloria help him, doesn't dismantle the underlying oppressive structures, and ultimately supports it.

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